



LESSON 6.2 THE BLUES SCALE: ORIGINS, CONSTRUCTION & CREATIVE USE

By Rob Lobasso | Alien Guitar Secrets

WHAT IS THE BLUES SCALE?

The **blues scale** is a modified version of the **pentatonic scale**, primarily used to add expressive “tension and release” to melodies and solos. It introduces a unique “bluesy” character by adding a special note: the **flat 5th** ($\flat 5$), often referred to as the **blue note**.

MINOR BLUES SCALE: DERIVED FROM THE MINOR PENTATONIC

The **Minor Blues Scale** starts with the **Minor Pentatonic** as its foundation and adds one additional note:

Minor Pentatonic Scale Formula:

1 – $\flat 3$ – 4 – 5 – $\flat 7$

Minor Blues Scale Formula:

1 – $\flat 3$ – 4 – $\flat 5$ – 5 – $\flat 7$

Example in E:

- **E Minor Pentatonic:** E – G – A – B – D
- **E Minor Blues Scale:** E – G – A – **B $\flat$** – B – D

The **$\flat 5$ (B $\flat$)** becomes the dissonant “tension” note that adds a gritty, vocal-like inflection when used tastefully, especially with **string bends**, **slides**, and **vibrato**.

MAJOR BLUES SCALE: DERIVED FROM THE MAJOR PENTATONIC

Just as the **Minor Blues Scale** is built from the **Minor Pentatonic**, the **Major Blues Scale** is a variation of the **Major Pentatonic**, with the same additional note – the **$\flat 5$** – added for colour.

Major Pentatonic Scale Formula:

1 – 2 – 3 – 5 – 6

Major Blues Scale Formula:

1 – 2 – $\flat 3$ – 3 – 5 – 6

Example in G:

- **G Major Pentatonic:** G – A – B – D – E
- **G Major Blues Scale:** G – A – **B $\flat$** – B – D – E

Here, the **$\flat 3$ (B $\flat$)** adds a bluesy feel in a **major context**, allowing for a soulful blend of brightness and tension.



SUMMARY OF RELATIONSHIPS

Scale Type	Formula	Derived From	Expressive Quality
Minor Pentatonic	1 – b3 – 4 – 5 – b7	Natural Minor (Aeolian)	Dark, punchy, melodic
Minor Blues Scale	1 – b3 – 4 – b5 – 5 – b7	Minor Pentatonic	Gritty, expressive, vocal-like
Major Pentatonic	1 – 2 – 3 – 5 – 6	Major Scale (Ionian)	Bright, open, melodic
Major Blues Scale	1 – 2 – b3 – 3 – 5 – 6	Major Pentatonic	Soulful, funky, playful tension

APPLICATION TIPS

- **Bend into the blue note** (b5 or b3) rather than land on it and hold.
 - Use the **blues scale over both major and minor progressions**, depending on feel.
 - Combine **major and minor blues scales** for colourful hybrid phrasing.
 - **Improvise freely** using the 5-box system by inserting the extra b5 note in each shape.
 - Emphasise phrasing over speed. The tension from blue notes needs proper resolution.
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FINAL THOUGHTS

The **blues scale** is the gateway to expressive soloing. It's built on the solid foundation of the **pentatonic system**—so once you've mastered your five box shapes, incorporating the blue note opens a powerful new dimension in your playing.

Whether you're channelling the grit of **Gary Moore**, the finesse of **Joe Bonamassa**, or the innovation of **Steve Vai**, this scale will become your secret weapon.